Reformer Assessment Class

45 minutes · exercise sequence

REFORMER – 45 MIN – FULL BODY
PROPS: SMALL SOFT BALL PER REFORMER, SHOULDER-REST BLOCKS, KNEE PAD, WEDGE ON HAND

RUNNING CLOCK

CLOCK	SEGMENT	TIME	SPRING	FOOTBAR
0:00	Intro & screening	2 min	–	–
2:00	Warm up – footwork & bridges	5.5 min	RR	Up
7:30	Core, hands in straps	7 min	R – the only change	Up
14:30	Legs, first side	5.5 min	R	Up
20:00	Core, plank family	6 min	R	Up
26:00	Legs, second side	5.5 min	R	Up
31:30	Back chain & arms	8 min	R	Down
39:30	Cool down	4.5 min	R	Down
44:00	Outro	1 min	–	–
45:00	**End**	**45 min exactly**	**1 spring change**	**1 change**

Two checkpoints to memorise: start the second leg side at 26:00, start the cool down at 39:30. If you are behind at either, drop the back block's optional exercises first, then cut reps there – not in the second leg side, and not in the cool down.

SPRING PLAN

RR (warm up) → **R** (everything else: core / straps, legs, plank block, back, cool down)
One spring change, well under the maximum of three. The call at 7:30: "take one red off – one red only, and that's the only change today. Footbar stays up." One bar change at 31:30 (bar down for the back block), with no spring change attached – the core section uses the raised bar as the leg-extension target.

Load is managed with range and position rather than springs. In the back block, everyone sits closer to the straps, since one red is heavy for arm work. Fallback if the room is mostly beginners or several people flag shoulders: a blue at 31:30 with the bar change (still only two changes).

The ball is held in the arms (footwork, Long Lunge, Scooter), threaded under the tabletop leg or passed under the thigh, and squeezed between the knees (Bridges, plank block through the push-up). It goes down for the Flying Lunge and both Elephants, and isn't used in the back block.

WARM UP – FOOTWORK AND BRIDGES: 5.5 MIN

Spring: RR (footbar up)
Lying supine – feet on footbar, hips width apart, ball held in the arms for the footwork. Dynamic, all three planes. Order: Pilates V → toes → balls of the feet → one leg → heels (bridges) → Roll Up.

- Leg Press – Pilates V, balls of the feet, heels touching, toes apart, ball held over the chest x 8 press out and in
    - Small pulses near straight legs, knees soft x 8
- Leg Press – toes on the bar, parallel, hip width, ball in the arms x 8
    - Small pulses near straight legs x 8
- Heel Raises – same foot position, legs straight, holding the ball x 6 full range
    - Small pulses at the top x 6
- Prances, holding the ball x 20 alternating – slow and even, then quicker and lighter
- Double Leg Press – balls of the feet, parallel, hip width, ball in the arms x 8, slow return
    - 3 counts out, 3 counts home to advance
- Single Leg Extension – one foot stays on the bar, other leg to tabletop, find neutral first x 6 each side
    - Option 1: press the carriage out and thread the ball under the tabletop leg, hand to hand – knee stays at tabletop
    - Option 2: extend the leg long over the footbar as the carriage comes in, bend the knee back as you press away – flexed toes, heel pressing into the bar
    - Knee slightly past tabletop if the ball won't thread; don't let the hip grip
- Glute Bridge – heels on the footbar, ball between the knees
    - Find neutral first: tuck, arch, settle in the middle, a few ball squeezes there
    - Articulating x 3 – squeeze the ball at the top and hold the squeeze all the way back down to neutral
    - Small lift and lower x 8, squeezing the ball each lift – glutes and hamstrings keep the carriage parked
- Glute Bridge 2, press out & return – hips high, press the carriage away and pull it back in x 6
    - Hips lower an inch or two as the carriage goes out, lift as it comes in; ball squeezed throughout
    - Then park the carriage: small pulses x 6 → hold the squeeze, lower 10% and lift x 6 → hold, breath in, roll down
    - Small press, or lower the hips between reps to regress · slower return to advance
- Pilates Roll Up – ball down, legs long x 4, the last one stays seated
    - Bent knees with hands behind the thighs, or a half roll-back, to regress · slower down phase to advance
    - No roll up for pregnancy, low back or osteoporosis – roll to the side and press up to sitting

After the last press-out, return the carriage, roll down and set the ball beside the carriage. The last Roll Up finishes seated – the spring change happens there. Call it from your own reformer so everyone sees the colour, then walk and check.

> *Pre-cue: "Last roll up – stay sitting at the top. Spring change: take one red off. One red only, and that's the only change today. Footbar stays up. Then roll back down and take your straps, and I'll check as I come round."*

CORE, HANDS IN STRAPS: 7 MIN

Spring: R (the only change – footbar stays up)
Supine, straps in hands, arms above the shoulders. One red asks more of the shoulders – regress with smaller arm range and head down.

- Arm Press Down x 8 – head down
    - Feet on the carriage to regress · legs to tabletop to advance
- Abdominal Curl x 8 – press the arms down and curl up on the same breath (no rotation)
    - Feet on the carriage, head down, press only, to regress · legs to tabletop to advance
- Curl + Single Leg Extension x 6 each side → Double Leg Extension x 6
    - Curl and hold, extend one leg at a time, then both together
    - Head down, or single leg only, to regress · lower the legs to advance
- Set 1 – Curl + Double Leg Extension **over** the footbar x 4
    - Double Leg Extension **under** the footbar x 4
    - Hold the extension
    - Legs only – bend and extend x 4, arms and curl stay still
    - Scissors all the way up and all the way down x 4 each side
    - Bend the knees and return to the start
    - Stay over the bar, head down, smaller scissor to regress
- Set 2 – Curl + Double Leg Extension, hold
    - Tricep Press in the hold x 6 – elbows bend and straighten, upper arms still
    - Hold again
    - Flutter Kick x 20 beats – small and quick
    - Return to the start
    - Head down, legs higher, or tricep press with feet on the carriage to regress · lower legs, slower tricep press to advance
- Hundred x 100 beats
    - Legs to tabletop or head down to regress · legs to 45° to advance

Roll up to seated, step off to the side. No spring change, no bar change – say "same spring, one red" out loud so nobody reaches for a spring out of habit.

LOWER BODY – FIRST SIDE: 5.5 MIN

Spring: R (unchanged – footbar up)
Standing foot on the floor, back foot against the shoulder rest. Run all four on one side, then leave it. Ball in the arms for the Long Lunge and Scooter – put it down before the Flying Lunge.

- Long Lunge, ball held at the chest, no reach x 8
    - Lunge + reach the ball up x 8
    - 1 lunge, 1 ball pass under the front thigh, return x 6
    - Lunge hold, ball passing only x 8
    - Shorter range, hold the ball still to regress
- Scooter, ball held in the arms, pressing straight back x 8
    - Press back + 1 standing-heel raise each rep x 8
    - Hold the back leg long, heel raises only x 8
    - Ball down, hands on the bar, heel stays down to regress
- Flying Lunge – knee tuck, ball down, hands on the bar x 10
    - Foot stays on the ground to regress · full tuck to full extension to advance
- Flying Lunge – knee left / right / centre x 6 cycles

Four exercises in 5.5 minutes – the extra sets and the holds (the manual's "pulses and holds" variation) fill the time rather than a fifth exercise. Allow about 15 seconds across the block for set-up between exercises.

Foot down, step onto the carriage and kneel, then pick up the ball and set it between the knees for Down Stretch. No spring change, no bar change, keep talking.

CORE – PLANK FAMILY: 6 MIN

Spring: R (unchanged – footbar up)
Ball between the knees from Down Stretch through the push-up, then down for both Elephants. Offer fists or forearms **before** the first exercise, not after someone is uncomfortable.

- Down Stretch, ball between the knees x 8
    - Smaller extension, chest lifted less to regress · full range, longer carriage travel to advance
- Long Stretch, ball between the knees x 6
    - Knees down to regress · full plank, longer press to advance
- Plank, ball between the knees, hold x 3 breaths → Push-up x 8
    - Knees down to regress · slower lowering to advance
- Elephant, ball down x 8
    - Soft knees, smaller carriage travel to regress · heels down, longer range to advance
- One-Leg Elephant stretch, ball down x 5 each side
    - Shoulders square and facing forward – no hitching up on the lifted-leg side
    - Lifted foot stays low to regress · longer carriage travel to advance

Down Stretch is the only spinal extension in the class – it opens the block so the spine is lengthened before the plank work. Do not cut it.

From standing at the bar after the One-Leg Elephant, pick the ball up and set up for the second leg side.

LOWER BODY – SECOND SIDE: 5.5 MIN

Spring: R (unchanged – footbar up)
Pre-cue: "Step off to the side – back to the legs, other side this time. Same springs, nothing to change." Repeat the first side in full, same reps, same layers.

- Long Lunge, ball at the chest x 8 + reach the ball up x 8 + 1 lunge, 1 pass x 6 + lunge hold, passing only x 8
- Scooter with ball, straight back x 8 + heel raise x 8 + hold, heel raises only x 8
- Flying Lunge – knee tuck, ball down x 10
- Flying Lunge – knee left / right / centre x 6 cycles

Teach this side differently: halve the set-up cueing and spend the time walking, observing and adjusting – the best window for observation, hands-on adjustments and active teaching.

From the Flying Lunge, step off to the side. Bar down, spring stays on one red. Then sit or kneel facing the straps and cross them.

BACK CHAIN AND ARMS: 8 MIN

Spring: R (unchanged – footbar down, the only bar change)
Seated or kneeling facing the straps. Straps crossed for the three rows, then uncrossed for everything after – not a spring change. Two optionals come straight after the uncross, and the optional Mountain Climber closes the block: all three are your time buffer. Everyone stays facing the straps to the end of the block.

One red is heavy for arm work: sit closer to the straps and move back only if the rows feel easy. Shoulders lifting to the ears = shorten the range.

- Low Row, straps crossed x 10
  - Smaller range to regress · pause at end range to advance
- High Row, straps crossed, elbows to shoulder height x 10
  - Elbows lower, smaller range, sit closer to regress · pause at end range to advance
- Single-Arm Row with Rotation, straps crossed x 8 each side
  - Sit closer, smaller rotation, or no rotation to regress · free hand reaches the opposite way to advance
- *Optional:* Shoulder Retractions, straps uncrossed, straight arms, drawing back to the hips x 8
- *Optional:* Reverse Fly, open out x 8
  - Smaller opening, sit closer to regress; skip it with a shoulder flag
  - Lift up into a V to advance
- Bicep Curl, straps uncrossed x 10 – light and rhythmic
  - Hold the last curl, then press the arms up overhead x 6
  - Small press to forehead height, or skip the press, to regress · longer hold before the press to advance
- *Optional:* Mountain Climber, straps down, still facing the straps x 10
  - Plank, hands on the frame at the strap end, feet on the carriage – draw both knees in, press back out to a long plank
  - Knees down (kneeling), smaller range to regress · alternate knees, quicker tempo to advance

> *Pre-cue: "Last press – hold it up there. Now put the straps away and come onto your hands on the frame, feet on the carriage, still facing this way. Footbar stays down, same spring."*

The Mountain Climber is the sixth wrist-loaded exercise – offer fists again before it starts, and a knee pad for the kneeling version.

Skip all three optionals and you are ~2½ min early – hold the cool down for 8 breaths, not 5.

COOL DOWN: 4.5 MIN

Spring: R (unchanged – footbar down)
Static holds only, calm voice, minimal cueing, music noticeably down. The sequence descends seated → kneeling → supine, so nobody has to get back up.

- Mermaid, side-seated, reach up and over x 5 breaths each side
- Kneeling Hip Flexor Stretch x 5 breaths each side
    - Quad stretch – same position with the back foot caught
- Figure 4, supine, strap or bar to draw the leg in x 5 breaths each side
- Final Twist, knees side to side, arms wide x 5 breaths each side
- Final breath – long, still, hands on the ribs x 20 sec

If you arrive here at 40:30 instead of 39:30, drop the final twist. Do not speed up the rest.